not offer an apology to anyone." Saying that he considered Savarkar his idol, Uddhav asked Rahul to refrain from insulting him.

Even on the Adani issue, while the Opposition parties united on seeking a joint parliamentary committee (JPC) to probe the allegations, the TMC and BRS have often stayed away from Congress-led agitations. Any attempt to project Priyanka in the absence of Rahul may also antagonise some allies who see the party's obsession with the Gandhis as counter-productive.

Will History Repeat Itself?

Regardless of support from other parties, several senior Congress leaders are looking upon this as an historic opportunity to turn disqualification into political revival for Rahul just as it did for his grandmother nearly five decades ago. Indira Gandhi, too, was disqualified from Parliament and debarred from holding any elected post for six years after the Allahabad High Court convicted her on charges of electoral malpractices on June 12, 1975. However, she declared Emergency soon after even though the Supreme Court overturned her conviction in November 1975. Public anger against her saw Indira Gandhi losing even her own seat in the 1977 election, but an ill-advised arrest by the Morarji Desai-led Janata Party government later that year saw her regain public sympathy and make a massive comeback in the next general election. She had projected herself as a lone warrior against a group of ideologically riven political stalwarts who had come together only to grab power. What also aided her return to power were stunning newspaper visuals of her atop an elephant en route to the nondescript village of Belchi in Bihar, where some Dalits had been murdered. Rahul, too, stares at a jail term and has famously talked of waging a lonely battle against the might of the BJP-RSS. He has also provided enough photo-ops during BJY, like the time he delivered a speech in Mysuru, braving a downpour.

However, unlike his grandmother, Rahul is up against the organised might of the Sangh Parivar and the unprecedented popularity of PM Modi, and not a disjointed political coalition. The Congress's lack of firepower to combat BJP's carpet-bombing narrative has been all too evident in the past.

The BJP, in fact, has already begun a carefully curated campaign against Rahul, citing the current defamation case as an example of his disrespect for the OBC community. While Rahul has invited punishment for defaming a surname that can be found among upper castes and is common even to Parsis, the BJP is picking on Rahul naming PM Modi, an OBC, among others. This is because the OBCs have played a key role in bringing the BJP to power in the previous two Lok Sabha elections. The party's OBC support has doubled from 22 per cent in 2009 to 44 per cent in 2019. Among the big states going to polls this year, OBCs form more than half of the population in Karnataka and Telangana while in Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh and Chhattisgarh, they account for more than 40 per cent of the population. Parliamentary affairs minister Prahlad Joshi, a senior BJP leader from Karnataka, has already held a meeting of the party's OBC MPs and directed them to take up the issue of "Rahul Gandhi insulting OBCs" vigorously.

IF RAHUL IS OUT OF THE ELECTORAL RACE, THE **BJP WILL BE ROBBED OF ITS CHIEF TARGET**, AROUND WHOM THEY HAVE OFTEN BASED THEIR POLITICAL CAMPAIGNS

Misfired Gambit for BJP?

Not everyone, though, is sure that the BJP's gambit will pay off. Rahul's disqualification has fired up the Congress, brought almost the entire opposition together and lent strength to the narrative that the Modi regime is muzzling the voice of democracy, exactly what Rahul Gandhi accused them of on foreign shores. More significantly, if Rahul is not reinstated and cannot contest the 2024 election, he will rob the BJP of its chief target, around whom the party weaves its entire campaign. This, too, may boomerang on the ruling party.

As per the BJP's calculations, Rahul's disqualification will force the Opposition to focus their narrative on him, which works to the saffron party's advantage. PM Modi has always retained the edge in a Modi vs Rahul contest, as successive India Today Mood of the Nation polls and parliamentary election results have shown. In both 2014 and 2019, in the 100 seats across six states—Rajasthan, Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Himachal Pradesh and Uttarakhand—where the Congress and the BJP were pitted directly against each other, the grand old party won only three seats each time.

There are doubts within Rahul's own party too. "Rahul loves scoring a self-goal," says a Congress Lok Sabha leader. "After the success of BJY, he had no business to go abroad and talk about Indian democracy. Even though he painted a true picture, the criticism on foreign soil gave the BJP the 'nationalistic' ammunition to attack him and diluted the gains from BJY."

Rahul may have the moral high ground and the sympathy and support of Opposition parties, but the real challenge will be if he can channelise this unity into electoral gain. The Congress has outlined a series of agitations it will carry out till April 30 and Rahul himself is keen on another yatra. But whether this becomes a journey of revival or oblivion will depend on the narrative the Congress can build and how strongly the leadership and organisation can communicate it. It has been said before but bears repetition: It's now or never. For Rahul and his party. ■